policy. They argue that these committees enable detailed discussions of issues, create an environment where a small number of people, politicians and bureaucrats, can sit and discuss issues.

Critics assert that what the committee achieves depends upon how interested parliamentarians are in foreign policy issues and how willing they are to contribute to discussions on foreign policy. According to former diplomats most parliamentarians are interested not in broad issues of foreign and security policy but rather in issues like passports, visas, cultural exchanges, and of course on any issues to do with India's neighbours because all these have a domestic dimension. While the committee can call officials it does not have the power to call a minister or the prime minister.

According to most analysts, parliamentary oversight is not as intense as it used to be in the early years. According to academics and former diplomats, Nehru would always be in parliament to answer questions and would never miss question hour unless he was out of town. After Nehru, however, most prime ministers including Indira have preferred to avoid parliament when they can. Further, while all ministries, including Ministry of External Affairs, provide answers to parliamentary questions, accountability is not what it used to be or what it should be. Thus the only time the parliament is really interested in foreign affairs is when it is a critical issue.

'THE STEEL FRAME'

Even though India's prime minister, his cabinet and parliament are the major pillar of India's government, it is the professionally trained civil service that is described as the 'Steel Frame' of government in India. That depiction dates back to a 1922 parliamentary speech by British prime minister David Lloyd-George. The Indian bureaucratic system and especially the foreign service is a legacy of British colonial rule with a history dating back to the British East India Company.